# CULTURE VS. NATURE?

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ABSTRACT

We are living in a world reaching a critical point where the equilibrium between a healthy climate environment, the energy our society needs to maintain or improve this lifestyle and the interconnected economies could pass more quickly than expected from the current complex balance to a complete new reality where unbalance would be the rule and human beings would need to be as creative as never before to survive.

Have the arts a role in all this? Have artists a responsibility in this context?

While listening to scientists, politicians, engineers, economists, philosophers, sociologists, technology specialists and policy-makers reflecting and debating about the fast changes of our environment seems to be something almost natural today, artists voices are increasingly taking a prominent role around these matters too.

It is remarkable how different societies react to this problem. Similar situations are seen under a different perspective in different countries, regions or cities. While people have mid- and long-term confidence on "the system" in some places, there is a general disbelief in others. The same could be observed in the artists' concerns regarding environmental issues. These are not the same in all latitudes.

The arts could play a major part in helping the global society to understand the magnitude of the crisis we are facing, and in promoting the awareness around environmental matters. And it could also be a very good vehicle to disseminate proposals that could produce changes in our behavior and decisions, influencing our chances for the future. Artists could promote inter and transdisciplinary actions focusing on the global environmental crisis and our responsibility regarding the turning point we are living in defining the future of life on Earth.

Electroacoustic music/Sound art and associated approaches could be a key point in the network of creative actions to help each of us find reasonable and peaceful strategies of survival (and empowerment). Biomusic, *musique concrète*, soundwalk practices, soundscapes, sound field recordings, sound ecology and soundmaps are just a few examples; the possibilities are endless if we think about music and sound-based artistic works related to other art forms as well as to a multitude of scientific fields.

Before we used to talk about the four basic elements of nature: water, earth, air and fire but now we are talking more about matters such as: climate change, biodiversity, water supply, air quality, food chain and even geo-engineering, among others.

The world is changing faster than we can - individually- perceive it.
Music and musicians have a lot to do with the surrounding world but we need to build the bridges, to open the communication channels and to develop the dialog strategies.
Electroacoustic music has many faces, and one could be to become a powerful tool of awareness and transformation, to the benefit of us all.

Culture distinguishes from nature but we enjoy the aesthetics of our wild environment. Do we need to confront culture vs. nature? Is that the only way we have learnt in our civilized world? Many of us have been living in an almost fully artificial environment most of our lives, forgetting that we only have one place, even if global, just one. We can move around but still we are contained inside the same big space.

The arts can be a catalyst to explore transdisciplinary intersections between nature, science, technology and society. As we move into an era of unprecedented ecological threats, the arts could be one of the keys to engender a deeper awareness of our critical situation and could also help to develop intellectual partnerships to work in the solving of our global environmental crisis.

Today, while writing this text, I was listening in the news about the ecological devastation, and the loss of species in the world's ocean, comparable to those great mass extinctions of

prehistory. Overfishing, pollution, acidification and more: what this has to do with music? What this has to do with us, musicians, artists/researchers, composers? If organic means something related or derived from living matter, from living organisms, produced by or found in plants or animals: What do we expect of our future? What do we do for our future? And, Are we, musicians, part of that future?

Life and live music. The beauty of nature and the beauty of culture. The physical forces and the intellectual mind. We need to search for the equilibrium between culture and nature if we want to have a future for the humankind, if we aim to find the organic in harmony with sophisticated sounds, if we hope to have organic sounds available to still be able to create live electroacoustic music!

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